

Arctic fox

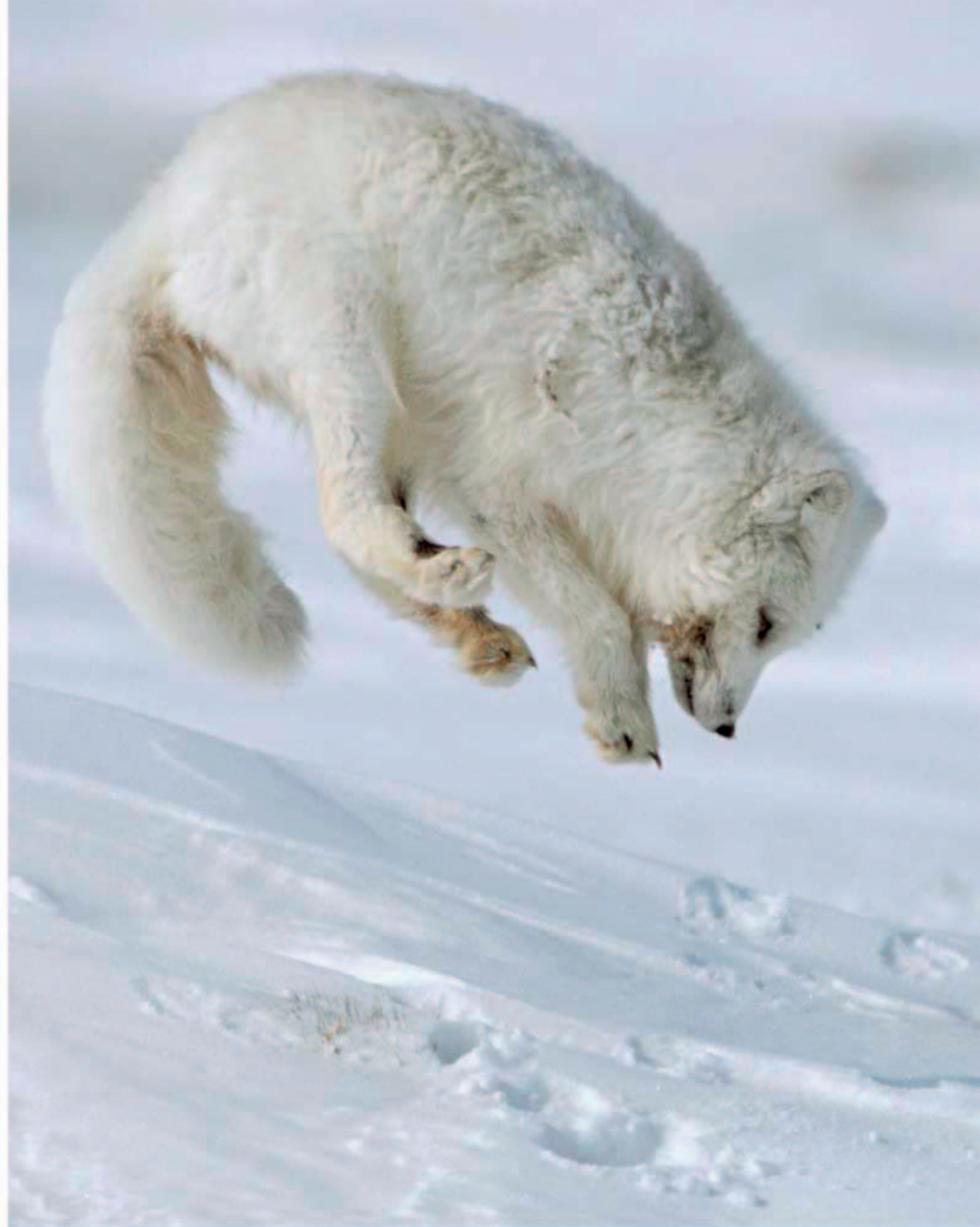
Alopex lagopus

Incredibly well-adapted to its harsh environment in the Arctic Circle, the Arctic fox can survive temperatures as low as -58°F (-50°C). Its dense fur is a few inches thick during winter, insulating its short ears, muzzle, and even the soles of its feet, which allows it to walk on ice without slipping. In winter, most Arctic foxes grow a white coat (some turn a steely blue) that lets them blend into the snow.

Varied diet

Although it feeds on smaller mammals such as lemmings, voles, and Arctic hares in summer, in winter the Arctic fox may dig out seal pups from their under-ice birth chambers. It will also follow polar bears and wolves to feed on carcasses they leave behind. The Arctic fox is the most common predator of Arctic birds such as snow geese, but also eats fish, eggs, seaweed, and berries.

Mainly solitary, Arctic foxes may congregate around carrion or fresh kills, and regularly raid garbage dumps in northern Alaska. When not hunting, the Arctic fox curls up in underground burrows during summer, while in winter it tunnels into snow banks to escape blizzards. Females give birth in spring to litters of as many as 14 kits, or pups. Both parents raise their young until around August, when the family group disperses.



The Arctic fox has the **warmest pelt of any animal found in the Arctic**

- ↔ 21–22 in (53–55 cm)
- 🐾 9 lb (4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐾 Small mammals, fish, birds
- 🏠 



N. Canada, Alaska, Greenland,
N. Europe, N. Asia



△ HUNTING IN THE SNOW

The Arctic fox listens for movement below, then leaps into the air before plunging head-first to the ground. This force breaks through the snow to the prey beneath.

< SUMMER COAT

Arctic foxes' white coats thin and change color to gray-brown in summer to match surrounding rocks and low-growing vegetation of the tundra.